CONNEXUS black sea tech forum | 2026

The City You Stop Noticing

A resident's account of Dubai as a smart city

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ICT CLUSTER VARNA

BSMEPA
BULGARIAN SMALL AND MEDIUM ENTERPRISES PROMOTION AGENCY

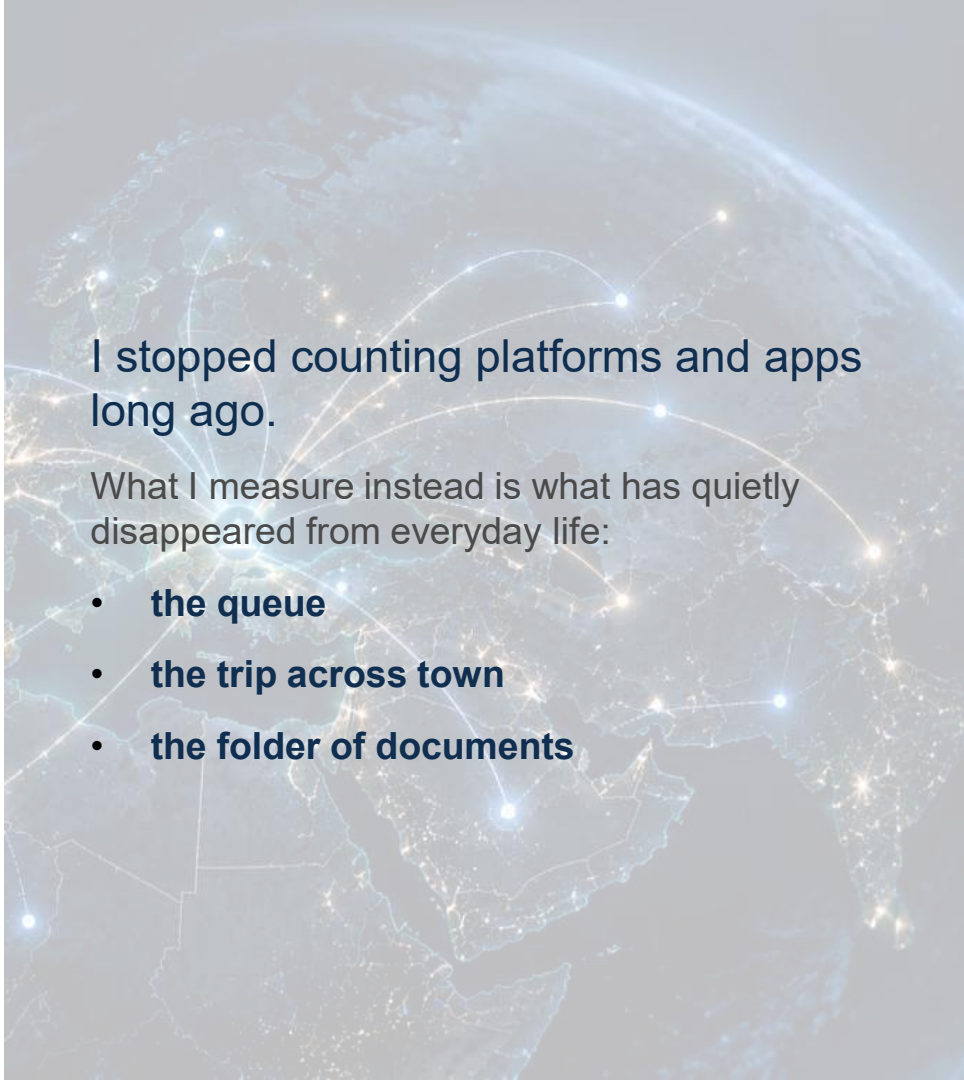
BAPHA

BRAIN++ AI FACTORY

ARC FUND

Living inside a smart city

Resident for eleven years.



I stopped counting platforms and apps long ago.

What I measure instead is what has quietly disappeared from everyday life:

- **the queue**
- **the trip across town**
- **the folder of documents**

What visitors notice

Dubai in the headlines



Robotaxis
Carrying paying passengers since March 2026. Target: 1 in 4 trips autonomous by 2030



Air taxi vertiport
World's first certified, at DXB



Drone delivery
Meals to lockers, Dubai Silicon Oasis



Red Carpet corridor
Leave DXB without showing a passport

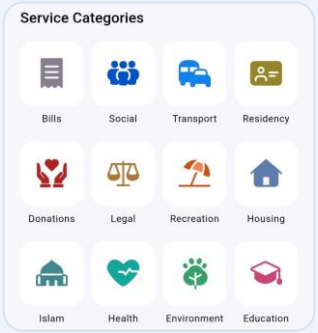


Driverless Metro
Running without drivers since 2009

Visitors photograph these. Residents notice something else: what disappeared.

A resident’s measure

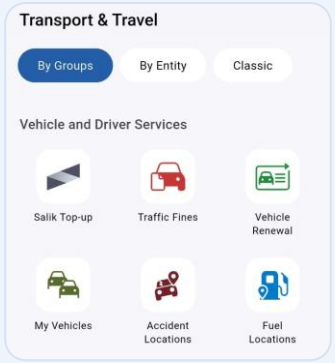
What quietly disappeared



Bills, residency, transport and more in one app

The queue

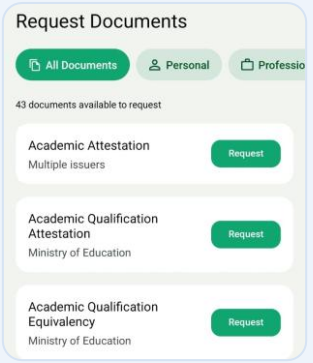
Bills paid, fines settled, visa and Emirates ID renewed — all from one app on my phone.



Vehicle renewal in DubaiNow; the card arrives at the door

The trip across town

Car registration renewed on my phone. The new card was delivered to my door a few days later.



Ministry of Education attestation, requested in the app

The folder of documents

School certificates attested online for a university application. One UAE PASS identity for every government service.

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336 million

sheets of paper removed from Dubai Government transactions — strategy launched in 2018, completed in December 2021

45
government entities, no exceptions

1,800+
services digitised

AED 1.3 bn
saved

14 million+
work hours saved

Source: Government of Dubai Media Office, 11 December 2021

Not mainly a technology story

The decisions behind it

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A deadline and a mandate

One date for every government entity: paperless between 2018 and 2021.

One identity, not one login per agency

UAE PASS: 12.5 million+ users, 15,000+ services from 350+ entities.

One front door

DubaiNow: 370 services from 50+ entities. Residents do not need to know which department does what.

Willingness to pilot in public

Unstaffed police stations; robotaxis in commercial service since March 2026.

The technology was available to many cities. The difference was deciding quickly — and carrying it through at scale.

Sources: Biometric Update (Sep 2026); Gulf News (Feb 2026); Dubai Media Office (Mar 2026)

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What changes

In practice



Time

The hours that went to queues and trips across town come back to you.



Predictability

You know how long something will take — and it takes that long.



A service, not a place

Government becomes something you use, not somewhere you go.

What it asks of the people inside it

The other side of convenience

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01 **Trust**

One identity connects everything: documents, licences, fines, payments.

02 **A phone as the front door**

And a plan for the day it fails.

03 **Everything connected**

Tolls, fines and records reach you instantly.

04 **Keeping everyone in**

Who helps the residents who are less digital — older people, newcomers, visitors?

The less you notice the system, the more you rely on it.

The City You Stop Noticing

What is the first thing you would want to disappear from an ordinary day in Varna?

Thank you

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